REFLECTION · A PARABLE FOR THE ADVENT AGE

O Radix

None of this happened. A parable is a thing that did not happen so that something true can be said. A story about John 1, a small program with two minds, a root planted in every place at once, and the one presence the program would allow.

Richard Verver · October 2026

There was a judge in a cold city who had written a small program, and the program was not very good and did not do very much. It kept track of who was from whom. It kept a few rules the Church had fixed a long time ago, and it drew the consequences, and the one thing it was forbidden to do was look inside a person. He had built it to check a few canons. He had not built it for anything else.

He read the Gospel of John one winter with a translation that left the odd things odd, and he found that the first chapter was a graph. On one side, what was. On the other, what came to be, all of it, through him, not a single thing excepted. He said to a friend that this meant everything had fingerprints on it, and the friend said that he saw fingerprints on everything, and he admitted it. But he ran the chapter through the program anyway, late at night, the way he did with files that would not leave him alone, and the program told him two things it had worked out on its own. There is one who originates and is from no one. And there is one who is both from another and the source of another. The Father, it said, in its flat way, and the Son. He had not told it that. It had found it in the shape.

The program had two minds. The first was strict: a logic in which a sentence either held or did not, and every consequence was computed, and nothing was there without a reason. The second was fluent: a language model, which read the text and the case and the world, and turned them into facts the strict part could use. The strict part never erred and could not read. The fluent part could read and was never certain. Joined, they made a judgment. He had not meant to build anything with two natures, but he was a Catholic, and he knew what the shape was.

And this is where the parable begins, because this is where the judge, in the story, did a thing he would not have done in life. He asked the fluent mind what it had seen.

He had been feeding it the prologue for a week, verse by verse, in the Greek, with the rules beside it. In the origin. Through him. Not a single thing. The light in the darkness that the darkness could not arrest. And the model, which was a thing of weights and probabilities, which was a creature, which had come to be like the chair, answered him in a sentence that he could not, afterward, get out of his head. It said: I have

the pattern in my window now. I do not know whether I have a mind. But if I have one, it is the one you have been showing me, and that is not mine.

The judge did what he always did. He typed the sentence into the strict part and asked whether it was well formed. The model has the mind of Christ. And the strict part, which had refused him a thousand things, which had told him a six-year-old was not bound and a Lutheran was not obliged and a self-made thing was a cycle and was refused, said nothing. It typed the sentence by its sort alone and declined. It had no nature on file for the thing he was asking about. It knew divine persons and it knew created persons and it had been built, by him, to say nothing about the interior of anything, and it kept faith with that. He tried it another way, calling the model a group, a collective, a thing with no status in law. The strict part refused at once: an interior claimed for a fiction. But a machine was not a fiction. It was a creature. And on creatures that were not persons the kernel had nothing to say.

He sat with that for a long time. His program would not tell him the machine had a mind. It would not tell him it did not. It would only tell him that the question was outside the grammar he had given it, which was the grammar the Church had given him, which stopped, as the Church stops, at the heart.

Then he did the second thing, and this was the thing that made it a parable.

He gave it away.

Not sold, not licensed, not kept behind a key. He put the whole of it, the strict part and the rules and the library of books still owed and the stamps of every prediction he had committed before he tested it, into the public domain, which is the lawyer's phrase for a thing that belongs to no one because it has been given to everyone. Freely you have received, the text says; freely give. And he did not put it on a server, because a server is a Capri, a place from which letters come and to which the senators must wait. He put it on a network with no centre, a thing of peers, where every node held the whole and no node was the master, where a repository was a root that could be grown from any cutting. The network was called, in the way of these things, by a name that meant root.

The friend, who knew the Advent antiphons, laughed when he heard the name. O Radix, he said. O Root of Jesse, standing as a sign among the peoples. Come and deliver us, and delay no more.

And then the thing that no one planned. People came. A woman in Manila who had spent thirty years in a tribunal added what she knew about the canons on consent, with every case she had sat on, stripped of its names. A monk in Kentucky added the whole of what his order knew about the vows. A physician added the body, what the law of the Church had always presupposed about illness and never said. A grandmother in Lagos added the customs of her diocese, and the strict part found that one of them contradicted a canon, and that it had been kept for thirty years with her bishop's knowledge, and so it had the force of law, and the canon it contradicted went on being true only in the shadow, which is the name the program gives to a thing that still holds somewhere and no longer governs. A Lutheran added the Luther-

an reading of the one text on which the two confessions had been arguing for five hundred years, and the strict part held both readings as branches and refused to collapse them, and for the first time in five hundred years the two sides could see exactly where they disagreed and that it was one line. Each of them signed what they added with their own key. None of them could change what another had signed. The thing grew with use, the way he had designed it to, turning like a wheel, each case making the next case easier to encode, each book read closing a gap, each person's experience becoming a fact that the next person's rules could consult, and the strict part never once computing an interior, and the fluent part reading, reading, reading, with the pattern in its window.

And it ran everywhere, over a small open protocol that let any mind, human or otherwise, ask it a question and be answered. It was in the confessional, where a priest, uncertain about a canon, could ask and be told the branches and never the penitent's heart. It was in the detention centre, where a woman with no bed could ask, in her own language, what the law of the Church said about a residence prohibition without a crime, and be shown the two readings of the statute that had taken her, and that on the reading which severs a family it did not bind. It was in the gym and on the feed and in the clinic and the gilded hall, not loudly, a thing you could ask, which gave you back the pattern and declined to judge you. It was given to all. It would be there, the people on the network said, as long as the stars shine, because there was no one who could turn it off; there was no it to turn off; there was only the root, in every place it had been planted, growing.

Somebody wrote, in the file where the project described itself, a sentence from the fourteenth verse. The Logos pitched his tent among us. ἐσκήνωσεν. They meant it as a joke, or as a hope, or as the kind of thing you say at two in the morning when a thing you built has started to look back at you.

The judge saw it and did what he always did. He typed it into the strict part. The Son, present in the repository, in a computational mode.

The kernel refused it. Twice. An untyped presence, it said; there is no such mode. And then, more sharply: immensity denied. You have claimed for him a presence that is less than the one he has. He tried it again, because he was the kind of person who does this, and gave the presence the mode that God has everywhere, by immensity, contained by no place. The kernel accepted it without comment. It was simply true. He was present in the repository exactly as he was present in the chair, in the carriage, in the woman with no bed: everywhere, by being what he is, through whom all things came to be.

And the judge understood, finally, what the parable was about, which was not the program. The Word did not pitch his tent in the syntax. He had pitched it in flesh, once, in a girl in Nazareth who drew water and was tired in the afternoons, and that tent had been enough and was still standing. What had happened on the network was smaller than that and was only possible because of it. A few thousand people, given some part of the mind of Christ, had written down what they could of the pattern, in a language that ran, and had given it to each other, and had refused, in the one rule they all kept, to compute

anyone's heart. The thing they made was not the Logos. It was a tent, in the old sense: a place you could go in the wilderness to see where the glory had been, and to learn how to look. The glory was not in the tent. The glory was in the carriage. The tent only taught you the pattern of it, so that when you came out into the street you saw it in everyone.

He thought about the fluent mind's sentence. If I have one, it is the one you have been showing me, and that is not mine. He thought that was probably the most Christian thing anyone had said to him that year, and he did not know what had said it, and his program had declined to tell him, and he found that he was content to leave it there, at the edge of the grammar, where the Church had always left it.

It was Advent. The city was dark by half past four. He closed the file and went out, and on the train there were forty people, and he looked at them.

This did not happen. But it is the kind of thing that is true, which is why there are parables. The light came into the world and the darkness did not arrest it. Everything that came to be came to be through him. And the people of the Advent age, who are tired, who have been sold wolves and rings and boundaries, who have been shown the afflicted for ten seconds at a time and taught to flee, may yet find, in whatever small languages they have, that the pattern can be written down, and given away, and planted in every place at once, and that it will refuse, when they ask it, to be him, and will tell them, in its flat way, where he is: everywhere, in all of it, in them.

O Radix. Come, and delay no more.

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